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# The Helms School of Government Scholarly Project Handbook



**This handbook is a guide to the research process for doctoral students at the College or School mentioned above. This handbook is subject to change at the discretion of Liberty University. This version of the handbook supersedes all previous versions.**

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# Contents


Introduction ..... 4
Welcome ..... 4
Purpose of the Handbook ..... 4
Doctoral Project Defined ..... 5
Administrative Contacts and Information ..... 5
Doctoral Community ..... 5
Student Support ..... 5
Student Complaints and Appeals ..... 5
Becoming a Doctoral Candidate ..... 5
Doctoral Project Coursework ..... 6
Coursework Sequencing ..... 6
Registration for Doctoral Project Coursework ..... 6
Faculty Support Structure ..... 7
Roles and Responsibilities ..... 7
Selecting Faculty Support Member(s) ..... 7
Appeal of Faculty Support Structure ..... 7
Overview of Doctoral Project Tasks ..... 8
Purpose and Structure of Doctoral Project Tasks ..... 8
Task Progression and Approval Requirements ..... 8
Graduation ..... 11
Appendix A ..... 12
Appendix B ..... 13
Appendix C ..... 14
Appendix D ..... 15
Appendix E ..... 16
Appendix F ..... 17
Appendix G ..... 18
Appendix H ..... 19
Appendix I ..... 20
Appendix J ..... 21
Appendix K ..... 22
Appendix L ..... 23

Appendix M .....24
Appendix N.....25
Appendix O.....26
Appendix P.....27

# Introduction

## Welcome

Welcome to the Helms School of Government. We offer doctoral programs in Criminal Justice (Ph.D. and D.C.J.), Public Administration (Ph.D. and D.P.A.), Public Policy (Ph.D. and D.P.P.), and Law and Public Policy (D.L.P.). The goal of our doctoral programs is to prepare students to conduct academic research that illuminates theoretical and practical issues of governance in ways that glorify God, strengthen our nation and its institutions, and protect the rights and liberties that belong to each of us as God's children.

The discipline of Criminal Justice entails the study of topics including criminal behavior and psychology, the institutions and procedures through which criminal activity is policed, and the processes by which suspected criminal activity is investigated and prosecuted, including defenses for the rights of the accused. The Helms School of Government offers students in the Criminal Justice program cognates in Homeland Security and in Leadership.

The discipline of Public Administration entails the study of how public institutions are managed, how public resources are allocated, how public services are delivered, and how public officials conduct themselves.

The discipline of Public Policy entails the study of how public policy problems are identified or defined or how public policies are developed, implemented, or evaluated. The Helms School of Government offers students in the Public Policy program cognates in Chinese Affairs, Economic Policy, Education Policy, Foreign Policy, National Security Policy, and Social Policy. We also offer a Doctor of Law and Public Policy.

Programs which grant the Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) degree require students to write a dissertation. A dissertation is a work of original research designed and conducted by a doctoral student that contributes to the body of knowledge in a particular academic field. A dissertation should explore a problem that is documented in the academic literature of the field. It should be grounded in, and contribute to, an established theoretical tradition in the field. It should be explanatory in nature, rather than simply exploratory. It should produce findings that are generalizable.

Programs which grant doctoral degrees other than the Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) degree require students to write a doctoral project. These programs include the Doctor of Public Administration (D.P.A.), Doctor of Criminal Justice (D.C.J.), Doctor of Public Policy (D.P.P.), and Doctor of Law and Public Policy (D.L.P.). A doctoral project is a work of original research designed and conducted by a doctoral student that brings academic research to bear on a practical problem. A doctoral project should draw from academic work to illuminate a problem of practice at a specific site or in a specific context.

## Purpose of the Handbook

The purpose of this handbook is to provide a comprehensive outline of the research process and its associated requirements. It serves as a complement to The Graduate School Handbook, University Policy Directory, The Graduate Catalog, The Liberty Way, and your Degree Completion Plan (DCP).

This handbook offers an overview of the doctoral journey, including procedures and the responsibilities of each stakeholder. Additional requirements and course assignments are available in Canvas. For further assistance, please refer to the Administrative Contacts and Information section of this handbook.

# Doctoral Project Defined

For this handbook, a **doctoral project** is a site-specific, evidence-based initiative aimed at addressing a problem or improving outcomes within a particular setting. Unlike traditional research, doctoral projects are not generalizable; they focus on applying knowledge to solve practical issues in a specific context. Some examples include capstone projects, applied research, and quality improvement initiatives.

# Administrative Contacts and Information

- For assistance with questions or to be directed to the appropriate individual or office, contact the doctoral support team at HSOGDoctoralPrograms@liberty.edu.
- Learn more about the academic department's administration by visiting our webpage.

# Doctoral Community

The Helms School of Government Doctoral Community is a non-term course in Canvas that provides essential information, guidelines, forms, and resources to support the doctoral students research process. Students are expected to follow processes and to meet expectations detailed in the Doctoral Community.

Students are prompted to auto-enroll in this course in CJUS, PADM, and PLCY 700. If you cannot access the link above, you may click here to auto-enroll in the Doctoral Community. If you have difficulty accessing the Doctoral Community, or have questions about its content, please email HSOGDoctoralPrograms@liberty.edu.

# Student Support

The candidate is encouraged to reach out directly to the professor for support. Please refer to the Administrative Contacts and Information section of this handbook if additional assistance is needed.

# Student Complaints and Appeals

If a candidate experiences issues with a professor or a specific department, a complaint may be filed through Beacon. This official appeal and complaint process is designed to address written concerns fairly, consistently, and, where possible, to resolve them to the complainant's satisfaction. Official appeal and complaint policies for the University, along with corresponding links, can be found here.

# Becoming a Doctoral Candidate

A doctoral candidate is a student who has successfully completed all **foundational** coursework and has received departmental approval to enter the **doctoral project** coursework phase of the doctoral program.

# Doctoral Project Coursework

The candidate is encouraged to consult their Degree Completion Plan (DCP) each semester to ensure graduation requirements are being met and to avoid delays in completing the program. Additional requirements and policies not found on the DCP may be found in The Graduate School Handbook, University Policy Directory, or The Graduate Catalog.

## Coursework Sequencing

| **Courses** (Find Courses Description Here) | **Type of Coursework** | **Key Activities** |
|---|---|---|
| CJUS/LPCY/PADM/PLCY 885 | Foundational | • Initial Topic Review |
| CJUS/LPCY/PADM/PLCY 887 | Doctoral Project | • Topic Approval<br>• Proposal Development<br>• Chapters 2 & 3 |
| CJUS/LPCY/PADM/PLCY 888 | Doctoral Project | • Chapters 1-3<br>• Proposal Defense |
| CJUS/LPCY/PADM/PLCY 889 | Doctoral Project | • Manuscript Completion<br>• Chapters 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 |
| CJUS/LPCY/PADM/PLCY 890 | Doctoral Project | • Final Defense<br>• Post Defense Revisions |

## Registration for Doctoral Project Coursework

The 885: Research Concept course is the student's transition from foundational coursework to doctoral project research courses. This course requires students to complete a research concept paper, consisting of a problem statement, literature review, research question, and research design. The research concept paper is designed to lay the foundation for the student's doctoral project.

To be successful in this course, students must identify an appropriate and viable research topic prior to beginning the class. As students are completing foundational coursework, and prior to requesting registration in the 885: Research Concept course (or its equivalent on earlier DCPs), students are expected to review, complete, and submit a Doctoral Research Proposal Review form (available in the Helms School of Government Doctoral Community). This should be done at least three weeks prior to the start date of the term in which they are intending to take the course. The student's research proposal will be reviewed by a relevant program director who will provide feedback. Students will be expected to address any feedback before or during enrollment in the 885 course. Please review the instructions in the Doctoral Community for detailed information about submitting the research review form.

To request registration in the 885: Research Concept course, students will submit an enrollment

request through the Registration Override Request (ROVER) form in Beacon. In order for this request to be processed, the student must include a completed Doctoral Research Proposal Review form. Please review the instructions in the Doctoral Community for submitting an enrollment request.

After passing 885, the candidate is automatically enrolled all future dissertation course enrollments and does not need to submit individual registration requests.

If further assistance with registration is needed, please refer to the Administrative Contacts and Information section of this handbook.

# Faculty Support Structure

## Roles and Responsibilities

This section outlines the key participants in the doctoral project process and their specific responsibilities. Each role plays a crucial part in guiding the candidate's research and ensuring it meets academic standards. Understanding these roles helps the candidate navigate the research process journey effectively and produce a high-quality manuscript.

**Project Chair:** The chair plays a pivotal role in guiding the candidate through the research process. As the primary advisor, the chair is responsible for providing expert guidance, ensuring the research process aligns with academic standards, and overseeing the candidate's progress from proposal development to final defense. The chair's responsibilities include reviewing completed chapters, offering constructive feedback, and helping the candidate refine the research. Additionally, the chair may collaborate with relevant stakeholders to ensure that all aspects of the research process, including methodology and subject matter, meet the rigor expected in academia.

**Methodologist:** The methodologist operates outside the committee, ensuring that the research design, data collection, and analysis methods meet rigorous academic standards. The methodologist provides expert guidance on methodology to ensure the study's validity and reliability, offering feedback on selecting appropriate methods aligned with the study's objectives. Additionally, the methodologist verifies institutional and field-specific research guidelines. The methodologist typically serves in an external oversight role.

## Selecting Faculty Support Member(s)

While students are preparing their Research Plan Review form, they should also review the HSOG faculty roster which is linked in the Doctoral Community to identify the names of multiple faculty with whom they may be interested in working. Students should review the faculty members' profiles and research interests to select individuals whose areas of expertise align with their own intended research area. Students will include their selection of potential faculty on the research plan form. The department will review the student's selections and match the student with committee member(s) based upon faculty availability.

## Appeal of Faculty Support Structure

The candidate may initiate an appeal of a Faculty Support Structure formation decision by submitting a written request to the Dean of the College/School. Please refer to the Administrative Contacts and Information of this handbook. A subsequent appeal may be submitted in writing to the

Associate Dean of The Graduate School. A final appeal, if necessary, shall be directed to the Dean of The Graduate School. The decision of the Dean of The Graduate School is final.

# Overview of Doctoral Project Tasks

## Purpose and Structure of Doctoral Project Tasks

Candidates move from completing coursework into independent research, culminating in the defense of the doctoral project. This process is designed to strengthen critical thinking, research skills, and subject matter expertise, preparing candidates to make meaningful scholarly contributions. The doctoral project phase is completed across four sequential research courses, 887 through 890. Each course is graded pass or fail and is structured around required tasks that must be approved before a candidate may progress. Below outlines the required tasks and the sequence in which they are completed.

## Task Progression and Approval Requirements

- **Task 1: Research Plan Worksheet Approval (887)**
  For the successful completion of the Research Plan Worksheet Approval, submit a completed Research Plan Worksheet for review and approval by your doctoral project chair and methodologist. This task confirms that the proposed study is clearly defined, feasible, and appropriately aligned to support progression into doctoral project development. Refer to Appendix A for program specific requirements related to this task.

- **Task 2: Working Draft of Chapter 2 Approval (887)**
  For the successful completion of the Working Draft of Chapter 2 Approval, submit your Literature Review chapter (Chapter 2) for approval by your doctoral project chair. This chapter must synthesize relevant scholarly literature that informs the research problem and research questions. Refer to Appendix B for program specific requirements related to this task.

- **Task 3: Working Draft of Chapter 3 Approval (887)**
  For the successful completion of the Working Draft of Chapter 3 Approval, submit your Method chapter (Chapter 3) for approval by your doctoral project chair. This chapter must clearly identify the research design, procedures, and methodological rationale for the proposed study. Refer to Appendix C for program specific requirements related to this task.

- **Task 4: Working Draft of Chapter 1 Approval (888)**
  For the successful completion of the Working Draft of Chapter 1 Approval, submit your Introduction chapter (Chapter 1) for approval by your doctoral project chair. This chapter must clearly present the background of the study, the problem and purpose statements, the significance of the study, and the research question(s). Refer to Appendix D for program specific requirements related to this task.

- **Task 5: Proposal Manuscript (Chapters 1-3) Approval (888)**
  For the successful completion of the Proposal Manuscript (Chapters 1–3) Approval, submit a complete proposal manuscript including Chapters 1 through 3 and all required front and back matter for review and approval by your doctoral project chair and methodologist. This task

confirms that the proposed research design is coherent, feasible, and methodologically sound. Refer to Appendix E for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 6: Pre-Proposal Defense Presentation Approval (888)

For the successful completion of the Pre-Proposal Defense Presentation Approval, submit your proposal defense presentation for review and approval by your doctoral project chair. The presentation must provide a clear, concise, and well-organized overview of your approved proposal manuscript (Chapters 1–3). Refer to Appendix F for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 7: Proposal Defense Approval (888)

For the successful completion of the Proposal Defense Approval, you must present and pass your oral proposal defense. Your doctoral project chair will attend. The proposal defense serves as a formal evaluation of your approved proposal manuscript (Chapters 1–3) and your readiness to proceed to data collection. Refer to Appendix G for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 8: Research Ethics Quiz (888)

Ethical responsibility is an essential component of all doctoral-level research and professional practice. Doctoral projects are typically designed to address a specific organizational problem and are not intended to produce generalizable knowledge. Researchers must always follow ethical principles when collecting information, interacting with participants, and handling organizational data. This task introduces key concepts related to ethical responsibilities in professional doctoral projects. Candidates will learn about research ethics and then complete a short quiz to demonstrate understanding of these principles. This activity prepares candidates to conduct ethical research within organizational settings. Refer to Appendix H for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 9: Data Collection Worksheet Approval (888)

For the successful completion of the Data Collection Planning Worksheet Approval, submit the completed worksheet outlining your planned data collection activities and timeline for review and approval by your doctoral project chair. This task ensures that your data collection plan is organized, realistic, and aligned with your approved research. Refer to Appendix I for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 10: Site Authorization Letter Upload Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Site Authorization Letter Upload Approval, submit the official site approval letter confirming approval of your study. Professional doctoral projects are typically conducted within a specific organization or professional setting. Before collecting any information, candidates must obtain official authorization from the site where the project will occur. This approval confirms that the organization understands the purpose of the doctoral project and authorizes the candidate to conduct the proposed project activities within that setting. This approval helps ensure that the project is conducted transparently and ethically within the organization and that organizational leadership is aware of the project's scope. Candidates must secure this approval before initiating any recruitment, surveys, interviews, or other data collection activities associated with the doctoral project. Refer to Appendix J for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 11: Data Upload Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Data Upload Approval, submit all final data collected for your study to your doctoral project chair for review. This task confirms that data collection is complete and that data is appropriately organized and aligned with the approved research design. Refer to Appendix K for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 12: Working Draft of Chapter 4 Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Working Draft of Chapter 4 Approval, submit your Results chapter (Chapter 4) for approval by your doctoral project chair. This chapter must present analyzed data aligned to each research question using appropriate analytic procedures. Refer to Appendix L for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 13: Working Draft of Chapter 5 Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Working Draft of Chapter 5 Approval, submit your Discussion and Conclusion chapter (Chapter 5) for approval by your doctoral project chair. This chapter must interpret findings, present conclusions, and suggest recommendations. Refer to Appendix M for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 14: Final Manuscript (Chapters 1-5) Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Final Manuscript (Chapters 1–5) Approval, submit a complete final doctoral project manuscript including Chapters 1 through 5 and all required front matter and back matter for review and approval by your doctoral project chair and methodologist. This task confirms readiness for final defense. Refer to Appendix N for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 15: Pre-Final Defense Presentation Approval (889)

For the successful completion of the Pre-Final Defense Presentation Approval, submit your final defense presentation file for review and approval by your doctoral project chair. The presentation must provide a clear, concise, and well-organized overview of your completed and approved doctoral project study. While awaiting feedback, continue preparing for the final defense. Ensure you complete any required Attendance Check-in to stay active in the course. Refer to Appendix O for program specific requirements related to this task.

### ◈ Task 16: Final Defense Approval (890)

For the successful completion of the Final Defense Approval, you must present and pass your oral final defense. Your doctoral project chair will attend. The final defense serves as a formal evaluation of your approved final manuscript (Chapters 1–5) and formally evaluates your final manuscript, the completed research study, and your readiness for degree conferral by the University. Refer to Appendix P for program specific requirements related to this task.

# Graduation

Graduation and Commencement participation policies, including eligibility requirements and deadlines, and application process are established by the Registrar's Office. Although participation in Commencement is not mandatory, the candidate is strongly encouraged to attend.

# Appendix A

# Task 1: Research Plan Worksheet Approval (887)

- **Research Topics (Graduate School Requirement):** Research topics and activities must uphold the moral and ethical standards that characterize Liberty University and reflect a commitment to fostering a community of scholars who are Champions for Christ. For more information, please review the Liberty University Research and Activities Policy.

- **Research Topic Discipline Alignment (Graduate School Requirement):** Research should align with the academic discipline. Alignment with cognates, concentrations, or specializations is encouraged but not required.

- **Research Design (Program Requirement):** All studies for doctoral research should include a rigorous production of scholarly knowledge. By contrast to dissertations, which are written for an audience of other academic researchers, doctoral projects are written for the benefit of one or more clients or end users who are practitioners. Doctoral project research is focused on a specific site. For doctoral project research conducted by students in the Helms School of Government, appropriate sites would include governmental agencies, departments, or other public contexts or organizations. The client or end user for the research is usually one or more members of the leadership of that public organization who can apply the findings of the research project in ways that will help the organization execute its public duties and responsibilities.

# Appendix B

# Task 2: Working Draft of Chapter 2 Approval (887)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix C

# Task 3: Working Draft of Chapter 3 Approval (887)

**Data Collection Method Guidelines (Program Requirement**): At least one data collection approach must be quantitative, and at least one data collection approach must be qualitative. You must conduct interviews as one of your data collection approaches. If there is a research-based rationale for not using interviews as one of your data collection approaches, you must submit a formal, research-based justification to your chair for review. All exemption requests must be approved by the Research Director. If an exemption is approved, you are still required to fulfill three data collection approaches.

**Interview Method Guidelines (Program Requirement**): A minimum of 5 participants, but no more than 10, must complete the interviews. The full interview protocol should typically include at least 10 open-ended questions. Pseudonyms must be used for all participants to protect confidentiality. You may use AI to transcribe your interview recordings; however, you must manually check the transcriptions while listening to the recordings to verify accuracy.

**Survey Method Guidelines (Program Requirement):** A minimum of 15 participants must complete the surveys. The survey must include a minimum of 10 prompts that are topic-focused (e.g., not related to demographics, etc.).

# Appendix D

# Task 4: Working Draft of Chapter 1 Approval (888)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix E

# Task 5: Proposal Manuscript (Chapters 1-3) Approval (888)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix F

# Task 6: Pre-Proposal Defense Presentation Approval (888)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix G

# Task 7: Proposal Defense Approval (888)

**Proposal Defense Protocol (Graduate School Requirement):** The chair is responsible for facilitating the proposal defense via Microsoft Teams ensuring that the session is recorded. The candidate is required to use a webcam, have reliable internet and phone connections, be in professional dress, be in a professional location, and have technological support on hand, if needed, to ensure the defense runs smoothly. The defense takes approximately one hour to complete.

**Proposal Defense Attendance (Graduate School Requirement):** The only people who should attend a defense are the candidate, the chair, LU invited faculty members, and invited LU doctoral students.

**Proposal Defense Presentation (Program Requirement):** All proposal defenses must be scheduled through the Helms School of Government doctoral support team to be considered official and valid defenses. Please review details about scheduling a defense in the Helms School of Government Doctoral Community.

# Appendix H

# Task 8: Research Ethics Quiz (888)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix I

# Task 9: Data Collection Planning Worksheet Approval (888)

**Data Collection (Graduate School Requirement):** The candidate must pass proposal defense and obtain site approval before data can be collected in accordance with the guidelines established in the approved proposal. Failure to do so may result in consequences such as a formal warning, suspension of research activities, loss of any unapproved data, academic probation, or dismissal from the program.

**Site Permission (Graduate School Requirement):** It is the candidate's responsibility to secure all necessary site and stakeholder permissions. The candidate should seek preliminary approval early in the research process. Liberty University cannot override a site's denial or request for additional paperwork. If a site revokes permission, the candidate must secure a new site and/or adjust the study accordingly. Because doctoral projects are site-specific, evidence-based initiatives aimed at addressing a problem or improving outcomes within a particular setting, they are not generalizable. Examples include capstone projects, applied research, and quality improvement initiatives. Generalizability is the extent to which findings from a study can be applied to broader populations or different settings outside the specific conditions of the original study. Even though your project may involve human subjects, most doctoral projects do not require Institutional Review Board (IRB) review and approval because they are not "generalizable" as defined by federal regulations (45 CFR 46.102(e)(1)). However, two exceptions to this provision include projects that will take place at Department of Defense Education Activity (DoDEA) schools and instances of leaders requiring documentation of IRB review before they will grant site permission. For more details, first check with your department's doctoral support team to see if IRB is required or visit the IRB website.

# Appendix J

# Task 10: Site Approval Letter Approval (889)

**Gaining Site Permission (Program Requirement):** When doctoral project research is to be conducted within a specific organization, the researcher must obtain and provide documentation of site permission from a relevant official at the organization who is authorized to provide such permission. Students who expect to conduct doctoral project research within a specific site should have informal conversations with those authorized to grant site permission well in advance of any formal request to ensure there will be no difficulty or delay in obtaining that permission. In cases where a researcher has been approved for a research proposal that will not require research to be conducted in a specific site or organization, the researcher may request that the requirement of a site permission letter be waived. The researcher's Committee Chair should request documentation of this waiver through HSOGDoctoralPrograms@liberty.edu.

# Appendix K

# Task 11: Data Upload Approval (889)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix L

# Task 12: Working Draft of Chapter 4 Approval (889)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix M

# Task 13: Working Draft of Chapter 5 Approval (889)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix N

# Task 14: Final Manuscript (Chapters 1-5) Approval (889)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix O

# Task 15: Pre-Final Defense Presentation Approval (889)

No additional requirements are specified for this task. Candidates are responsible for complying with all applicable University, Graduate School, College/School, course, and program requirements, including any instructions provided in Canvas.

# Appendix P

# Task 16: Final Defense Approval (890)

**Final Defense Policy (Graduate School Requirement):** This policy ensures consistency in doctoral defense scheduling, supports registration and grading timelines, and promotes timely degree completion. For more information, please review the Liberty University Final Defense Policies.

**Final Defense Protocol (Graduate School Requirement):** The chair is responsible for facilitating the final defense via Microsoft Teams ensuring that the session is recorded. The candidate is required to use a webcam, have reliable internet and phone connections, be in professional dress, be in a professional location, and have technological support on hand, if needed, to ensure the defense runs smoothly. The doctoral project defense takes approximately one hour to complete.

**Final Defense Attendance (Graduate School Requirement):** The only people who should attend a defense are the candidate, the chair, LU invited faculty members, and invited LU doctoral students.

**Final Defense Presentation (Program Requirement):** Once the candidate incorporates and addresses all feedback from their chair's reviews, the candidate should prepare for final defense. The candidate should discuss readiness for final defense with the assigned faculty member and schedule a mutually agreeable time for the defense. The candidate is responsible for identifying dates and times convenient for all assigned project faculty member(s). The project chair is responsible for facilitating the final defense via Microsoft Teams ensuring that the session is recorded. The candidate is required to use a webcam, have reliable internet and phone connections, be in professional dress, be in a professional location, and have technological support on hand, if needed, to ensure the defense runs smoothly. All final defenses must be scheduled through the Helms School of Government doctoral support team to be considered official and valid defenses. Please review details about scheduling a defense in the Helms School of Government Doctoral Community.